



Dramatic Elements - Macbeth

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MODEL

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Model

🔊 AUDIO

✎ ANNOTATION

👁 VIEW ALL

⌵ NUMBERS

Identification and Application:

- As you read, ask yourself, Who are the characters? What are the conflicts? Where is the action set?
- What information do the stage directions and other text features specific to a play provide?
- Think about how setting affects the characters and the plot.
- Think about how the actions of the characters shape the plot.
- Think about how the plot affects the characters and spurs them to action.
- Relate character, plot, and setting to the themes, or central ideas, of the text. How do these dramatic elements help express the theme of the play?

Model:

In this excerpt from Act I, Scene III of Macbeth, Shakespeare provides very few stage directions to describe the setting, characters, and action. For example, readers are only informed that the action takes place on a “heath near Forres,” which we could investigate further to discover means “a field near Forres, Scotland,” and that there is “Thunder,” which suggests that the action is taking place during a storm. In the absence of extensive stage directions, readers must rely on clues within the dialogue to uncover important information about the setting, characters and plot, all of which are important dramatic elements that help “build” the play and reveal its themes.

The scene opens with dialogue from the three witches, or “weird sisters,” which illustrates that they derive pleasure from causing trouble in the lives of men and have spun a dark spell that involves Macbeth:

FIRST WITCH: Here I have **a pilot’s thumb,**
Wreck’d as homeward he did come .

[Drum within]

THIRD WITCH: A drum, a drum!
Macbeth doth come .

ALL: The weird sisters, hand in hand,
Posters of the sea and land,
Thus do go about, about:
Thrice to thine and thrice to mine
And thrice again, to make up nine.
Peace! the charm’s wound up .

The information in the witches’ dialogue provides important information about their characters (they delight in causing havoc in the lives of men, such as by causing a storm to wreck a sailor’s ship “as homeward he did come”) and about the plot of the play (the pilot’s fate may foreshadow that of Macbeth, who now “doth come”). Readers are led to suspect that the witches plan to ensnare Macbeth in some kind of trap or curse: “the charm’s wound up.” The trap, we soon discover, lies in a prophecy, which the witches deliver to Macbeth in a three-part greeting:

FIRST WITCH: All hail, Macbeth! hail to thee, **thane of Glamis !**

SECOND WITCH: All hail, Macbeth, hail to thee, **thane of Cawdor !**

THIRD WITCH: All hail, Macbeth, thou shalt be **king hereafter !**

Although Macbeth is already thane of Glamis, he is not thane of Cawdor or king and is startled by being addressed as such. By calling him by those names, however, the witches may want to plant a dark seed in Macbeth’s mind, to make him think, “What if?” So will Macbeth be easily led astray by the witches? Just what kind of character is Macbeth? Let’s consider a passage of dialogue from Ross, a Scottish nobleman who arrives shortly after the witches vanish with a message from the king:

ROSS: **The king hath happily received, Macbeth,**
The news of thy success; and when he reads
Thy personal venture in the rebels’ fight,
His wonders and his praises do contend
Which should be thine or his: silenced with that,
In viewing o’er the rest o’ the selfsame day,
He finds thee in the stout Norweyan ranks,
Nothing afeard of what thyself didst make,
Strange images of death. As thick as hail
Came post with post; and **every one did bear**
Thy praises in his kingdom’s great defence,
And pour’d them down before him.

This passage provides important information about the setting or context of the play and about Macbeth’s character. It makes clear that a great and bloody battle has just taken place, in which Macbeth achieved great “success” and received “praises” from all, including King Duncan himself, for bravely defending the kingdom against rebels and the army of Norway. Ross’s report paints a very positive portrait of Macbeth’s character. He seems like a fearless and loyal subject of King Duncan, willing to risk his own life in the service of ensuring that the kingdom remains in Duncan’s control. He does not at this point seem to be an easy target for the witches’ schemes.

However, several important “asides” in the stage directions that accompany the dialogue that follows this passage enable us to gain access to Macbeth’s private thoughts spoken aloud without the other characters hearing—and to suspect, after reading them, that his character is more complex and may contain a deep and fatal flaw that could lead to his undoing. For example, when Angus delivers the news that Macbeth has been made thane of Cawdor, thus fulfilling one of the witches’ prophecies, Macbeth rejoices:

MACBETH: [Aside] glamis, and thane of Cawdor too!
The greatest is behind .

Already, Macbeth has begun to think of being king as an inevitable fact (“The greatest is behind”), despite the fact that King Duncan is still very much alive and well and looks upon Macbeth as a trusted subject. The actions Macbeth takes to make the prophecy come true will shape the rest of the plot, serve to define his character, and help develop the play’s theme.